*The Obedience of Faith - Week 3*

# Good Intentions Are Not Enough

***The question of worship is not "Will it work?" but "Has God spoken?"***

*"The first time you did not carry it; that is why the LORD our God attacked us, because we did not seek him according to the prescribed ordinance."*
(1 Chronicles 15:13)

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# The Revealing Pattern of Sacrifice and Obedience

## Jesus → Perfect Alignment with God's Will and Purpose (The Good)

***"Sacrifice and offering you did not desire, but a body you prepared for me… Then I said, 'Here I am; I have come → it is written of me in the scroll of the book → to do your will, O God.'"*** **(Hebrews 10:5, 7)**

***Obedience of Faith*** **: "I have come to do your will"**

***Sacrifice*** **: the full cost, a body, nothing kept back**

***Worship*** **: perfect heart**

***Religion*** **: perfect form**

**Aligned once by Jesus Himself, completely, in Him.**

***"By that will we have been made holy → once for all." (Heb 10:10)***

He completed the stack before He asked you to climb it. **Yours is a thank offering, not a payment. (Rom 12:1-2)**

*"I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that you present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable to God, which is your reasonable service. And do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind, that you may prove what is that good and acceptable and perfect* ***will of God****."*
(**Romans 12:1-2**)

# Uzzah and the New Cart

## 2 Samuel 6 → the problem began before the touch

David brings the Ark to Jerusalem → right goal, real joy, thousands worshiping. They load it on **a new cart** (2 Sam 6:3). Clean. Expensive. Respectful. And exactly how the Philistines had moved it (1 Sam 6:7).

**But God had already spoken:** the Ark travels on poles, carried on the shoulders of Levites → and is never touched (Ex 25:14–15; Num 4:15; 7:9). The cart was borrowed from the pagans, not from the Word.

The oxen stumble. Uzzah reaches out to steady the Ark → the most natural motion in the world → and dies (2 Sam 6:6–7).
**The touch was not the beginning of the problem. It was the moment an earlier failure came due.**

Months later, David gets it right, poles, Levites, the Law (1 Chr 15), and names the first failure exactly:
***"The first time you did not carry it; that is why the LORD our God attacked us, because we did not seek him according to the prescribed ordinance."*** **(1 Chronicles 15:13)**

Not "we lacked sincerity." Not "our motives were wrong."
**"We did not seek him the way he said."**

# A Repeating Pattern

## Sincere people, unauthorized methods, the same result

| Who | Text | What they did | Outcome |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Nadab & Abihu** | *Lev 10:1–3* | Offered “strange fire” God had not commanded | Consumed |
| **Saul (Gilgal)** | *1 Sam 13* | Offered the sacrifice himself → urgency, scattering army | Kingdom to pass from him |
| **Saul (Amalek)** | *1 Sam 15* | Spared the best “to sacrifice” → edited the command | Rejected as king |
| **Moses** | *Num 20* | Struck the rock instead of speaking → water still came | Barred from Canaan |
| **Jeroboam** | *1 Kgs 12* | Convenient worship: calves, new feasts, new priests | “The sin of Jeroboam” |
| **Uzziah** | *2 Chr 26* | A good king burned incense → not his to offer | Struck with leprosy |

**Never a lack of zeal.** Urgency (Saul), success (Moses → water still came!), and political wisdom (Jeroboam) were all real → and none authorized the change. Even a good result cannot justify an unauthorized method.

# The Same Warning in the New Testament

## The principle did not expire with the old covenant

**Jesus → human tradition as vain worship:**
***"These people honor me with their lips, but their heart is far from me, and they worship me in vain, teaching as doctrines the commandments of men."***
**(Mark 7:6–7, 9)**

**Ananias and Sapphira** (Acts 5) → the appearance of devotion with deception inside it. Judged at the birth of the church, not the old covenant.

**Corinth** (1 Cor 11:20) → same bread, same cup, same gathering,
yet: ***"it is <u>not</u> the Lord's Supper you eat."***
The form survived; the substance was gone.

**And the sharpest case → sincerity that was flatly wrong:**
***"I have lived my life with a clear conscience before God to this day."***
**(Acts 23:1)**

- Paul said this truthfully → and had persecuted the church with that same clear conscience (Acts 26:9–11).
- **<u>A clean conscience is a gift. It is not proof that you are right.</u>**

# The Principle: The Obedience of Faith

## Romans opens and closes with it

***"Through him we have received grace and our apostleship to bring about the obedience of faith among all the Gentiles."* (Romans 1:5)**
… and again at the very end: ***"to bring about the obedience of faith."***
**(Romans 16:26)**

Faith is not merely belief. Faith hears God's word, trusts His wisdom, and walks in the way He revealed → **even when another way looks easier, cheaper, or more effective.**

**One necessary distinction (Restoration teachers put it plainly):**

- An **institution** is what God established. We have no authority to change it.
- An **expedient** is a lawful aid that helps carry out what God commanded without altering it.
- *Carrying the Ark by poles was the institution. A smoother road would have been an expedient. The cart replaced the institution → that is the line.*

The governing question of all worship and teaching:

- **Not "Will this work?" Not "Do we mean well?" → "Has God spoken?"**
- *"Do not go beyond what is written" (1 Cor 4:6).*

# Discussion

## Ten minutes → this is the week's practice

1. Why does "it works" feel like divine approval? Where does that instinct come from → and where does Scripture correct it?

2. Where do we build "new carts" today → sincere improvements on what God prescribed? How do we tell an expedient from a replacement?

# Read Like a Berean

## For next week → eager, and examining

**For next week, read:**

- Romans 9:30–10:13 → Israel pursued righteousness and missed it. How? What were they sincere about?
- Watch for 10:3 → "seeking to establish their own righteousness, they did not submit to God's."

**Next week begins Unit II → Discernment:** *Two Righteousnesses, and How God Is Known. We turn from the failure of sincerity to the grace that answers it.*

**Carry this week in one sentence:**
***Sincerity and success are real → and neither one is the standard. "Has God spoken?" is.***

***"We did not seek him according to the prescribed ordinance." (1 Chronicles 15:13)***

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# The Road: Twelve Weeks

## From the Good, through sacrifice and testing, to commission

| | |
|---|---|
| **Wks 1–3**<br>**FOUNDATIONS** | The Good · sacrifice · why sincerity isn't enough |
| **Wks 4–6**<br>**DISCERNMENT** | Two righteousnesses · the Berean method · love in truth |
| **Wks 7–9**<br>**TESTING** | Covenant tests · the church's tests · living sacrifice |
| **Wks 10–11**<br>**GOD'S HOUSE** | Apostolic authority · created order |
| **Wk 12**<br>**COMMISSION** | Households · "by this time → teachers" |

***"Therefore, I exhort you, brothers and sisters, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies as a sacrifice → alive, holy, and pleasing to God…"***
**(Romans 12:1)**